

The Curious Analyst

Every senior analyst you'll ever admire once stared at a spreadsheet and had no idea what a pivot table was. This level isn't about tools. It's about building the one habit that makes every tool after this actually useful:

asking better questions.

UNLOCKS: THE CURIOSITY HABIT



By the end of this level, you'll be able to:

ASK · Ask a sharp question

Turn a vague "how are we doing?" into a specific, answerable question.

SPOT · Spot what's missing

Notice when a number is suspicious before you present it to anyone.

AUDIENCE · Know your audience

Understand who's actually going to use what you build, before you build it.

LOG · Keep a curiosity log

Build the habit that separates analysts who report from analysts who discover.

The one skill before any tool

Here's a secret nobody tells beginners: SQL, Excel, Power BI — none of it matters if you're answering the wrong question well. The analysts who get promoted fastest aren't the ones with the fanciest dashboards. They're the ones who ask "wait, what are we actually trying to decide here?" before opening any tool at all.

Try this framework on any data question you get:

- 1. What decision does this inform?** If the answer is "none," push back gently.
- 2. Who's asking, and why now?** Context changes what "good" looks like.
- 3. What would change my answer?** If nothing would, you don't need more data — you need a decision.

YOU'RE PROBABLY THINKING...

"I don't even know SQL yet — how can I ask smart questions?"

Good news: curiosity comes before syntax, not after. You don't need to write a single query to notice that "revenue went up 40%" seems suspicious for a company that didn't launch anything new that month. That instinct — "wait, really?" — is the entire job. The tools just help you chase it down faster.

Every level after this one gives you a new tool. This level gives you the reason to use them well.

Rookie mistakes & pro secrets

ROOKIE MISTAKE

Jumping straight into building a report before confirming what question it needs to answer. You'll build something technically correct and completely useless.

PRO ANALYST SECRET

Senior analysts spend 70% of their time understanding the question and 30% building the answer. Juniors do the opposite — and redo their work twice as often.

Mini Mission: The 5-Question Hunt

Find any spreadsheet you have access to — work, personal budget, even your phone's step count history. Write down 5 questions you're genuinely curious about, using the framework from this level.

EXAMPLE

Dataset: My monthly budget.

Question: "Why did my food spend jump in March?"

Decision it informs: Whether I need a stricter grocery budget going forward.

+ 50 XP ON COMPLETION

Your Curiosity Log

Question	Why it matters	What data would answer it

Print this page, or copy it into your own notes app — whatever gets it actually used.

Rate your Curiosity Confidence

Circle a number, then track it again at the end of Level 8 to see how far you've come.

1

10

1–3: You're just starting — that's exactly where Level 1 wants you.

4–7: You already question things, you just need a framework.

8–10: You could probably teach this level. Move fast, but don't skip the worksheet.

What's one number in your life you've never questioned?

Write it here:

There are no wrong answers here — only the beginning of a habit.

LEVEL COMPLETE



Badge Earned: First Spark

You finished Level 1: The Curious Analyst

Total XP: 150

"The questions you ask before you touch the data matter more than the tools you use after."

NEXT UP

Level 2: SQL Apprentice

Where curiosity finally gets a language to speak in.